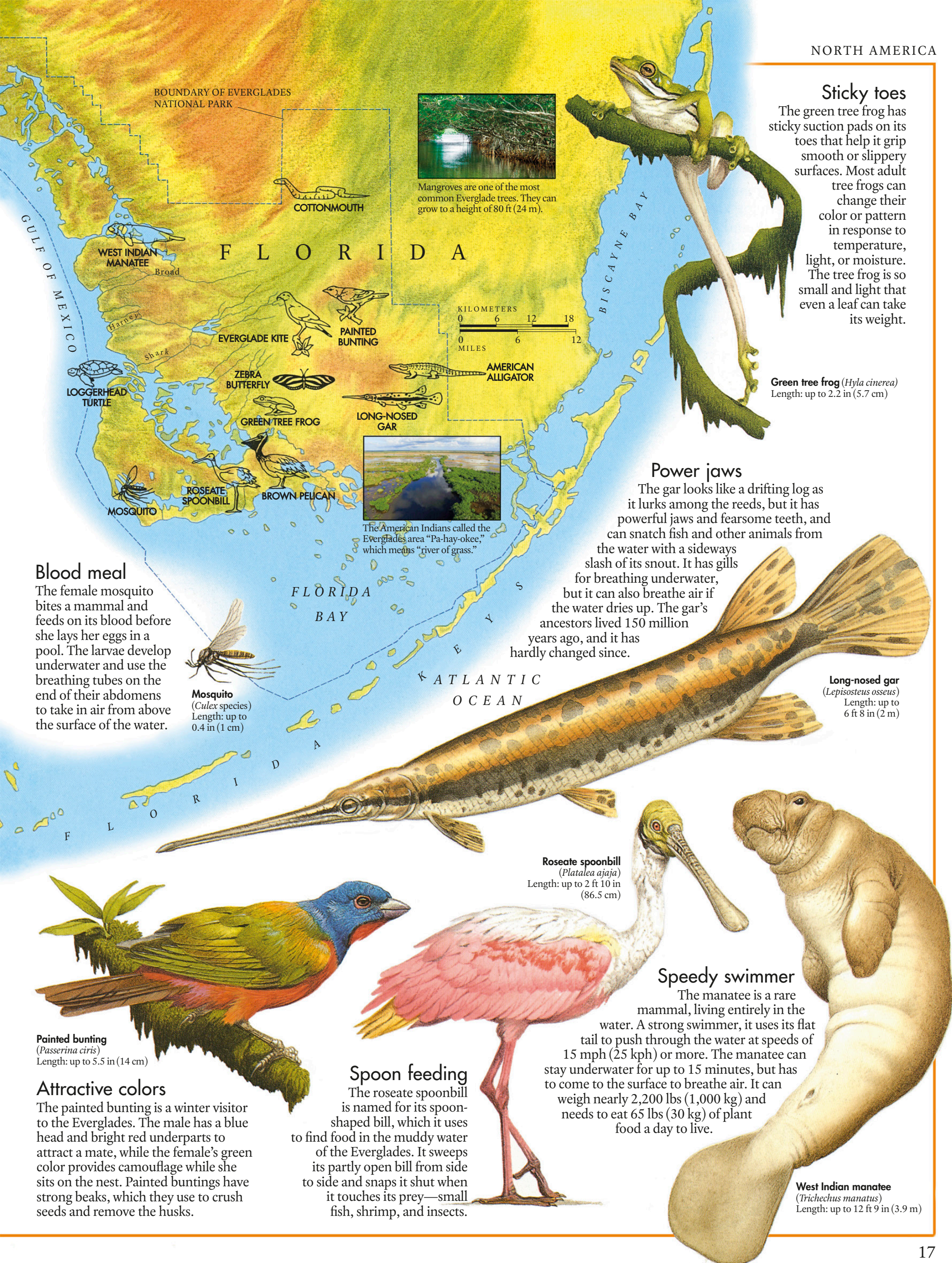




Sticky toes

The green tree frog has sticky suction pads on its toes that help it grip smooth or slippery surfaces. Most adult tree frogs can change their color or pattern in response to temperature, light, or moisture. The tree frog is so small and light that even a leaf can take its weight.

Green tree frog (*Hyla cinerea*)
Length: up to 2.2 in (5.7 cm)

Power jaws

The gar looks like a drifting log as it lurks among the reeds, but it has powerful jaws and fearsome teeth, and can snatch fish and other animals from the water with a sideways slash of its snout. It has gills for breathing underwater, but it can also breathe air if the water dries up. The gar's ancestors lived 150 million years ago, and it has hardly changed since.

Long-nosed gar (*Lepisosteus osseus*)
Length: up to 6 ft 8 in (2 m)

Blood meal

The female mosquito bites a mammal and feeds on its blood before she lays her eggs in a pool. The larvae develop underwater and use the breathing tubes on the end of their abdomens to take in air from above the surface of the water.

Mosquito (*Culex* species)
Length: up to 0.4 in (1 cm)

Painted bunting (*Passerina ciris*)
Length: up to 5.5 in (14 cm)

Attractive colors

The painted bunting is a winter visitor to the Everglades. The male has a blue head and bright red underparts to attract a mate, while the female's green color provides camouflage while she sits on the nest. Painted buntings have strong beaks, which they use to crush seeds and remove the husks.

Spoon feeding

The roseate spoonbill is named for its spoon-shaped bill, which it uses to find food in the muddy water of the Everglades. It sweeps its partly open bill from side to side and snaps it shut when it touches its prey—small fish, shrimp, and insects.

Roseate spoonbill (*Platalea ajaja*)
Length: up to 2 ft 10 in (86.5 cm)

Speedy swimmer

The manatee is a rare mammal, living entirely in the water. A strong swimmer, it uses its flat tail to push through the water at speeds of 15 mph (25 kph) or more. The manatee can stay underwater for up to 15 minutes, but has to come to the surface to breathe air. It can weigh nearly 2,200 lbs (1,000 kg) and needs to eat 65 lbs (30 kg) of plant food a day to live.

West Indian manatee (*Trichechus manatus*)
Length: up to 12 ft 9 in (3.9 m)